The Internet and Its Influence on Society

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I. Introduction

The internet, a new means of connection to a new society that began in the 20th century that's how I see it. It has had an immeasurable impact on people everywhere. Words like IT and social media are no longer just tools; they have transformed information, science, human relationships, news, learning, and entertainment. The internet has removed the barriers of distance, allowing instant access to personal information and communication.

Next, let's focus on the positive and negative impacts of social media on students.

Social media has had a revolutionary impact on students' education and communication. Platforms like YouTube and TikTok offer free educational content, enabling students to engage in self-directed learning efficiently. A survey targeting university students reported that social media facilitates information sharing, which improves academic performance, with over half of the students recognizing its positive effects. For example, YouTube's educational channels support learning in subjects like mathematics and science, enhancing student engagement.

On the other hand, data collection by internet companies increases privacy risks, exposing students to cyberbullying and data breaches. For instance, in the 2018 Cambridge Analytica scandal, Facebook users' data was misused, highlighting the issue of low privacy awareness among students.

II. Body

A. Internet as an Information Source

The internet has dramatically simplified access to information, promoting the democratization of knowledge. Before the internet, specialized knowledge was largely confined to books or academic journals, requiring time and expense to obtain. Search engines like Google and Bing have created an environment where users can instantly access vast amounts of information by entering keywords. As of 2023, Google processes approximately 9 billion searches per day, symbolizing the immediacy of information access (Statista, 2023). Additionally, as of 2025, Wikipedia hosts over 60 million articles, providing free, multilingual knowledge (Wikipedia, 2025).

This ease of access has also contributed to expanding educational opportunities. According to a Pew Research Center survey, 76% of internet users reported that online access to information has improved their learning capabilities (Pew Research Center, 2014). For instance, through MOOCs (Massive Open Online Courses), educational YouTube channels, and conferencing tools like Zoom and Microsoft Teams, learners in remote areas can now access university-level lectures. This has enabled the spread of knowledge beyond economic and geographic barriers, accelerating the democratization of information access.

B. Internet and Social Interaction

Next, let's focus on the positive and negative impacts of social media on students.

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C. Positive Effects

Before the internet, information was primarily provided through media such as books, television, and newspapers. Since the advent of the internet, it has revolutionized the way information is obtained, communication is conducted, and social interactions take place. Until the 20th century, books, newspapers, and face-to-face conversations were the primary means of information and interaction, but the internet has removed these constraints, offering immediacy and global reach. Search engines and social media have expanded opportunities for individuals to access knowledge, share opinions, and connect with people worldwide.

D. Negative Effects

Search engines and social media have expanded opportunities for individuals to access knowledge, share opinions, and connect with people worldwide. However, issues such as the spread of misinformation and the misuse of personal information have threatened societal trust and safety. For example, the convenience of Wikipedia, along with its susceptibility to tampering, is a case in point.

The Internet has dramatically transformed access to information, communication, and social interactions. Search engines and online platforms have promoted the democratization of knowledge, while social media and video conferencing tools have enabled cross-border exchanges. Yet, the spread of misinformation and privacy violations are significant challenges that threaten the trust and safety of the information society.

On the other hand, data collection by internet companies increases privacy risks, exposing students to cyberbullying and data breaches. For instance, in the 2018 Cambridge Analytica scandal, Facebook users' data was misused, highlighting the issue of low privacy awareness among students.

III. Conclusion

The Internet has revolutionized access to information, communication, and social interaction. However, it also poses challenges such as misinformation and privacy concerns.

The Internet has dramatically transformed access to information, communication, and social interactions. Search engines and online platforms have promoted the democratization of knowledge, while social media and video conferencing tools have enabled cross-border exchanges. Yet, the spread of misinformation and privacy violations are significant challenges that threaten the trust and safety of the information society. To address these, strengthening information literacy education, improving AI-driven content moderation, and enhancing data protection regulations are essential. By maximizing the benefits of the Internet while mitigating its risks, we can build an inclusive and reliable information society.

However, we must not forget: no matter how many laws are enacted or amended, ultimately, it is the consciousness of individuals in environments where the Internet is easily accessible that must change. Without this, the freedom of the Internet will diminish further, not only slowing the pace of further development and humanity's overall progress but also turning it into a privileged technology accessible only to a select few.

Access to information is a prime example. In the past, information was widely shared through

libraries and newspapers, but today, paid academic databases (e.g., JSTOR), premium news sites, and specialized data analysis tools are increasingly limited to the privileged or affluent. More extreme examples include China and Russia. Rather than merely reaping the benefits or passively accepting regulations, we must understand why these changes occur, anticipate what lies ahead, and prepare ourselves to avoid being swept away by the current.

IV. References

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